

■ By A. Rammohan Rao

**He is the Dronacharya of distance runners. Having shed the olive green fatigues of an infantry regiment havildar in 1996, he is honing the skills of bubbling youth, turning would-be layabouts into possible winners. His talent of spotting champions does not as yet rival the legendary Olympian Kipchoge Keino. Nor are his protégés,**

as yet, of the calibre of the tenacious all-time-great Ethiopian Abebe Bikila or his compatriot, the current world marathon record holder Haile Gebrselassie. But, atop the semi-arid Deccan plateau, in the RSCS Sainiki Vidyalaya in nondescript Sagroli, deep in the highlands of Nanded, Maharashtra, Bhagwan Nagargoje, 49, toils hard to achieve that elusive Indian goal—a gold medal winning Olympian in the star of all contests, the track and field.

Nagargoje is helping a generation of determined children, from orphans to juvenile home boarders, run to victory. "They have a fire in the belly, more space in their lungs and tougher fibre in their calves to run with determination," he says. He argues that such grit cannot be found among teenagers in cities and points to how the new Sagroli sportstars live up to his words. Not only have they won races at the district, state and national levels in Visakhapatnam, Tirunelveli, Pune and Aurangabad but also come out with flying colours in the Mumbai Marathon 2008, with village girls bagging the top three places.

Nagargoje spots the potential in long legged, lithe frames among the students at the school as well as the countryside beyond. In fact, his son and daughter were athletes before they turned medical students. "Different people have different talents," explains the committed coach adding that some have been given the idea of being brainy while others are regarded as brawny. Such categorisation doesn't exist for him. He believes whether there is money

in it or not, running is in their blood. "They have greater motivation because there was none so far to show them a goal and ways to achieve it," says Nagargoje who puts them through a strict training regimen. He is the Sagroli boys and girls what Madhavan Nambiar was to the sprint queen P.T. Usha—a full time, hands-on, son-of-the-soil coach who is determined to produce results and do his native Nanded district proud. "He is strict but doesn't force us to wear shoes when we say we are happy running barefoot," says Kanna Sunita Ram, 13-year-old girl, who shows some promise.

The budding stars are well into their first race by the time everyone else sets off for work in the morning. Fed on sprouts and strict vegetarian diet, the only concession Nagargoje allows them is occasional boiled eggs. An athlete in his own right, who won the 400-metre hurdles in the 1983 National Championships, Nagargoje is a stickler for food and practice. Although training methods for long-distance runners have changed with the advent of sports medicine and guided techniques, the benefits of running in the rugged environs up and down the hills in different climactic conditions have not. Running at higher elevations in the rugged terrain of the district builds greater lung capacity, because athletes grow accustomed to the thinner air.

"The bed of the river Manjira, the hillocks around, the tar road bridge which rattles under the impact of huge lorries and the narrow state highway in rain or shine prepares us for competition in all kinds

## marathon MISSION

★ **Bhagwan Nagargoje, 49**

**Project Training teenagers for long distance running**

**Can-do Icon** His senior Colonel Vikas Kapoor, for convincing him that sports is not just about the strength but also about the soul

**O** is the number of Olympic gold medals won by India in athletics

